

Human beings deserve Oscars. Not for acting in movies. For answering one very specific question. "How are you?" Think about it. Somebody asks. You smile. "I'm good." Meanwhile, you've had three mental breakdowns this week. You cried while washing dishes because a spoon reminded you of absolutely nothing, yet somehow it still felt personal. You've been surviving on tea, vibes, and the dangerous assumption that everything will magically work itself out. But yes. You're good.

You say it with a straight face, too. You practice the pitch of your voice so it doesn't sound too low, because a low voice invites follow-up questions, and follow-up questions are a trap. So you dial up the enthusiasm just enough to sound unbothered, give a little nod, and immediately ask them about their week before they can look at your eyes for longer than two seconds. It is a masterclass in deflection. We should be getting certified.

Honestly, whoever invented "I'm fine" deserves to explain themselves. Because "I'm fine" has become the Swiss Army knife of human emotion. "I don't want to talk about it." "I don't know how to explain it." "If I start talking, I might not stop." "I'm trying to convince myself I'll survive this." All translated into two innocent words. "I'm fine." We've become incredibly skilled at carrying invisible things. And we're so good at it that we've started congratulating each other for it. "You're so strong." Thank you. The alternative was collapsing in the Carrefour cereal aisle because life has become a little... expensive. Strength suddenly sounds much more attractive.

Because collapsing in public requires too much logistics. You have to deal with strangers offering you water, someone asking if you have a medical condition, and the sheer embarrassment of having to pull yourself together in front of the Corn Flakes. So instead, you tighten your grip on the trolley, stare intently at the price tags, swallow the lump in your throat, and convince your nervous system that this is just a very intense workout for your emotional resilience.

Imagine if emotional baggage had airport rules.

"Good morning."

"Any liquids?"

"No."

"Any unresolved childhood issues?"

"Several."

"Please step aside for additional screening."

No one really teaches us how to carry invisible things. Life quietly enrolls us. The first lesson usually comes much earlier than we realize. Maybe it was the first time someone laughed at something that mattered to us. Maybe it was the day we learned that crying in school meant becoming tomorrow's entertainment. Maybe it was hearing an adult say, "Stop crying. It's not that serious." Funny enough... Our hearts believed them. Not because they were right. Because they were older.

Have you noticed that children cry over everything? A broken biscuit. A balloon floating away. Someone taking the blue cup instead of the red one. Then one day we become adults.....and suddenly we're apologizing for crying over our parents dying. Somewhere along the way, we decided some pain was acceptable and other pain needed permission.

And when you are small, the adults are the architects of reality. If they tell you that your grief is too big for the room, you don't stop grieving; you just learn to squeeze it into a smaller pocket. You learn that expression equals exposure, and exposure leads to pain. So you construct your very first invisible compartment, tuck the feeling inside, and zip it up tight.

So we began editing ourselves. We swallowed words. Shrank emotions. Laughed before anyone else could laugh at us. Somewhere along the way we became our own emotional customs officers. "Sorry." You can't bring that sadness in here. Too much excitement? Leave that at the door. Fear? Absolutely not. People are already dealing with enough. Proceed. Travel light. Except... We never actually travel light. We simply become better at hiding the luggage.

We pack it down like clothes in a suitcase that won't close. We sit on the lid, zip it shut with sheer willpower, and then walk into the room pretending we're carrying a light tote bag. We become experts at the art of composure. You can be internally processing a life-altering realization while simultaneously approving a budget spreadsheet, offering advice on someone's outfit, and remembering to buy milk on the way home. It's terrifying how functional a broken heart can be when it has deadlines to meet.

Have you ever noticed how everyone says they're "busy"? Nobody says, "My heart feels heavy today." Imagine if we answered honestly. "How are you?" "Oh, not bad. Still processing something embarrassing I said in Form Two. Thanks for asking." Or... "I'm okay. My body has recovered from 2023 but apparently my brain is still holding weekly meetings about it." Ridiculous. Yet somehow... believable.

Imagine standing in a lift at work and saying, *"Honestly, my nervous system has been running on fight-or-flight since Thursday, but I'm really hoping this iced coffee fixes it."* The silence would

be deafening. People would look at the floor indicator like it was the most fascinating technology ever invented. So we stick to the script. We talk about the weather, the traffic on Uhuru Highway, or how fast the month is moving, because light topics keep the heavy luggage firmly on the ground.

Memory is strange. It has the organizational skills of a toddler. You forget where you placed your house keys. But your brain remembers that one awkward moment from 2014 with crystal clear audio. Amazing. You walk into a supermarket and hear an old song. Suddenly you're sixteen again. Someone wears the same perfume your grandmother used. Now you're standing in the baking aisle trying very hard to explain why onions have suddenly become emotional. They haven't. Your heart simply recognizes places before your mind does.

It's the weirdest kind of time travel. One second you're a responsible adult calculating inflation, and the next, a specific scent or a chord progression bypasses all your logic and drops you straight back into an old vulnerability. You aren't reacting to the supermarket; you're reacting to the ghost of who you were when that song first broke your heart.

And don't even get me started on Kenyan mothers. They'll ask, "What's wrong?" You'll reply, "Nothing." They'll look at you for exactly three seconds. "Sawa." Now somehow you've become the one feeling guilty. No further questions. No investigation. Just "sawa." That single word has ended more emotional negotiations than any therapist ever could.

Because that "sawa" isn't an agreement. It's a sovereign decree. It means, *"I know you're lying, you know I know you're lying, and we are both going to pretend this conversation didn't happen while I silently evaluate your life choices from across the kitchen."* It carries a terrifying, omniscient weight that leaves you standing there wondering if you should just confess to things you haven't even done yet.

We're fascinating creatures. A stranger in a matatu will tell you about their cousin's business, their landlord, fuel prices, the government, and the mysterious neighbor who definitely owns three goats illegally. But ask some of us how we're really doing... "We're okay." Are we? Or have we simply become fluent in emotional camouflage?

It's easier to talk about the goats. It's safer to complain about the price of unga or the state of the roads, because those are public problems. They belong to everyone. But your internal weather? That's private property. And inviting someone onto private property means risk. It means they might judge the terrain, or worse, notice how much work it needs.

Maybe that's why the smallest acts of kindness undo us. Someone remembers how you take your tea. Someone notices you've become quieter lately. Someone says, "You don't seem like

yourself." And suddenly your eyes are negotiating with your tears. "Not here." "We're in Quickmart." "This is not the place." Because being seen is exhausting when you've spent years trying to disappear behind competence.

It shatters the illusion. When you spend all your energy maintaining a carefully constructed wall, a single moment of genuine tenderness doesn't just knock on the door, it threatens to take the whole house down. You realize that your strength wasn't actually peace; it was just hyper-vigilance in a very nice jacket.

That's another funny thing. The people who look like they've got everything together usually have the most impressive collection of invisible backpacks. One bag contains grief. Another contains disappointment. One carries childhood. Another carries the pressure of being "the responsible one." Somewhere there's an entire suitcase labelled, "Things I never said." And somehow... They still remembered your birthday. Still showed up to work. Still made everyone laugh. Still replied, "I'm good."

Being "the strong one" is a full-time, unpaid job with no off-days and terrible benefits. People get so comfortable with you being the pillar that they forget pillars also experience structural fatigue. They bring you their problems, their storms, and their chaos, assuming that because your hands look steady, your heart must be unbreakable. Nobody checks the foundation of the house that is holding everyone else up.

We've become emotional weightlifters. Not because we enjoy lifting. Because life kept adding plates and nobody asked whether we wanted to continue the workout. Sometimes I wonder what would happen if invisible things became visible. Imagine walking into a café. Instead of handbags and laptops, everyone arrives dragging transparent suitcases. One reads, "Fear of failure." Another says, "Still misses Dad." Someone else's says, "Trying to forgive myself." The loud businessman in the expensive suit. The university student. The cashier. The pastor. The couple laughing in the corner. All dragging something.

You'd see the guy who just cut you off in traffic carrying a bag that says "*Terrified of losing my job*," and suddenly your anger evaporates into an uncomfortable pity. You'd see the person who was rude to the waiter dragging a suitcase that reads "*Exhausted from being invisible*," and you'd realize that half the friction in the world isn't malice at all. It's just people stumbling over the heavy things they're trying to carry through narrow spaces.

I think we'd become gentler overnight. Maybe we'd stop assuming silence means arrogance. Maybe we'd stop calling people "cold" when they're actually exhausted. Maybe we'd stop asking, "What's wrong with them?" And start wondering, "I wonder what they're carrying."

Because the truth is... Most people aren't difficult. They're tired. Tired of pretending. Tired of performing. Tired of translating every emotion into, "I'm fine."

They are tired of maintaining the broadcast. Tired of acting as the producer, director, and lead actor in their own daily comedy show just to make sure nobody gets uncomfortable. They don't need a standing ovation; they just need permission to step off the stage for five minutes without the theater burning down.

Maybe healing isn't finally putting the backpack down forever. Maybe it's finding people who don't immediately try to unpack it for you. People who don't tell you to "move on." People who don't compare your pain to someone else's. People who simply sit beside you and say, "That looks heavy." What a beautiful sentence. Not, "I'll fix it." Not, "You'll get over it." Simply... "That looks heavy."

Because when someone acknowledges the weight without trying to rewrite your story, something incredible happens. The burden doesn't magically disappear, but the isolation around it does. You stop feeling like a solitary worker hauling stone up a mountain. You realize that the weight was never the problem; the problem was having to pretend it was as light as air.

Sometimes understanding weighs far less than advice. Perhaps that's what we've been searching for all along. Not perfect lives. Not perfect mental health. Not the impossible dream of never carrying anything again. Maybe we've simply been looking for someone willing to walk beside us long enough that, for a little while, the backpack doesn't feel quite so heavy. Because invisible things don't disappear when we ignore them. But they do become easier to carry when someone reaches over, smiles, and says, "Here. Let me carry this with you for a while."

What should i write about next??